



This might seem like good news for someone who wants to believe in God without arguments. But it leaves us without a real answer to the challenge posed to religious belief by Pastafarianism.

Let's return to the idea of a basic belief you should have. If you think that we should believe that other people are conscious, then it seems like we need to think that there are some basic beliefs you should have of which we cannot be certain and for which we have no sensory evidence. After all, our belief that other people are conscious seems to be (for all we have said) a basic belief you should have.

Here's one idea we might try out. Certain claims just **seem** true to you.

It isn't that you can be certain that they are true, or that have sensory evidence that they are true. They just seem true.

Surely the religious believer should want to say that there is some sense in which their religious belief is reasonable, while Pastafarianism is not.

But they seem to be completely on par. We are conceding (for now) that we have no good arguments for either; but we have no good arguments against the Pastafarian. So what's the difference?

Maybe just the fact that it seems true to us that other people are conscious, and we have no argument against that claim, is good reason for us to believe it. That suggests the following positive rule of belief:

## Seems $\rightarrow$ Belief

If it seems to you that P is true,  
and you have no argument  
against P, you should believe P.

I want to look now at three challenges to this kind of rule of belief.

The first goes back to Descartes. His idea was that if we don't carefully examine our whole structure of belief, we can allow error to slip in. Surely just going by how things seem is not going to be a foolproof way to escape error! So why is this not just an irresponsible way to go about forming beliefs?

A second response to this is suggested by the following quote from

William James.

“There are two ways of looking at our duty in the matter of opinion ... We must know the truth, and we must avoid error. These are our first and great commandments as would-be knowers; but they are not two ways of stating an identical commandment, they are two separable laws.”

In this spirit, one might say that Descartes' advice is the best one if we only care about minimizing error. But this is not our only aim: we also want to believe the truth. If we limit ourselves to the beliefs we can be certain of, we will in so doing prevent ourselves from believing many truths.

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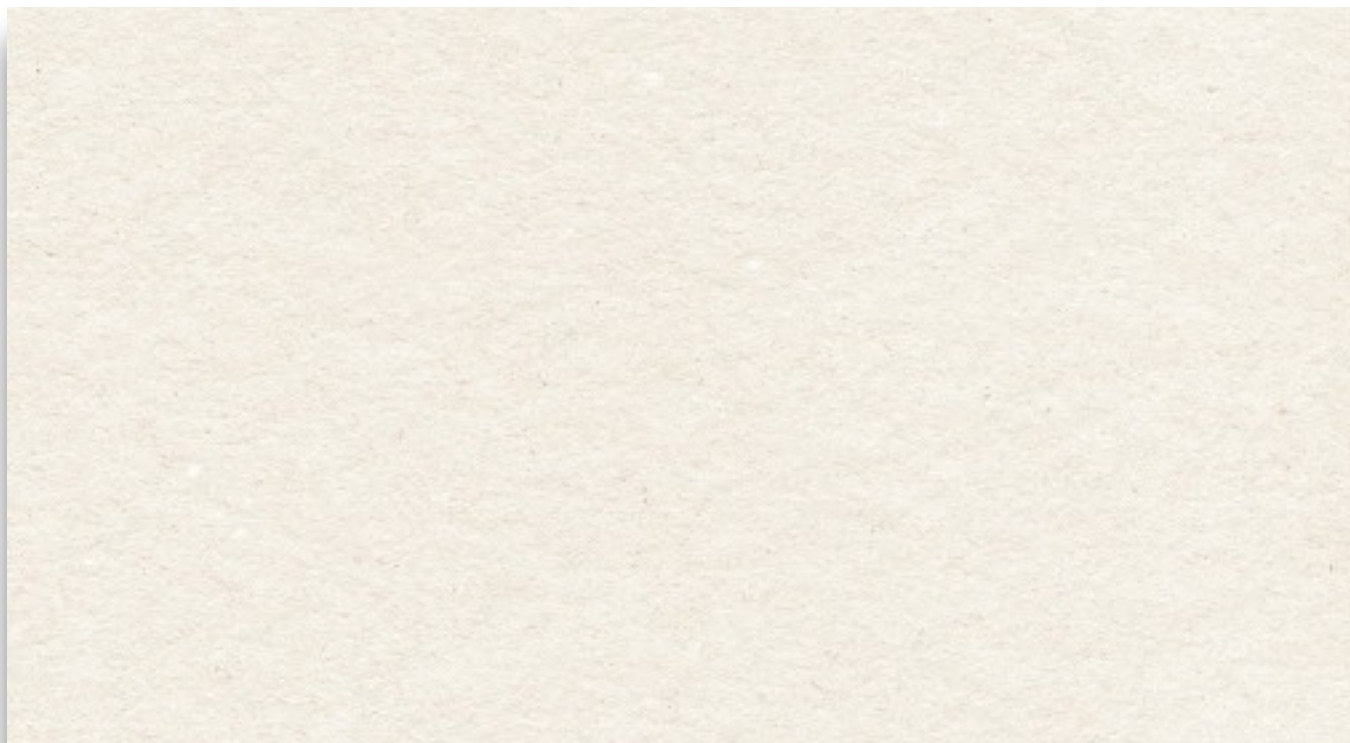
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No Prof

No Belief

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If you're not distinguishing

Don't → No Belief

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in which not- $P$ , do not



dislike it.

If you can prove P,



Let's take stock. We've not considered three

candidate rules of belief.

principles are open to substantial challenge. But

badbeisfs.

principles which explain why certain beliefs are

We've seen that both of our 'no belief'

surely, one might think, there must be some

Pastafarianism has its uses. For example, it can be used to get

religious exemption from the rule that one cannot wear a hat

in a driver's license photo:

Arizona

DRIVER LICENSE

USA

NOT FOR FEDERAL IDENTIFICATION



9 CLASS D

9e END M

12 REST NONE

1 CORBETT

2 SEAN MICHAEL

8

4b EXP [REDACTED]/2045

15 SEX M

18 EYES HAZ

16 HGT 5'-07"

19 HAIR BRO

17 WGT 250 lb

DONOR ♥

4d DLN [REDACTED]

3 DOB [REDACTED]/1980



4a ISS 05/04/2017

[REDACTED]/80

*Sean Michael Corbett*

As you might guess, many Pastafarians take somewhat

than serious attitudes toward the tenets of Pastafarianism. But it

can be used to make a serious philosophical point.

take it, be inclined to think that there is something irrational

about their beliefs.

But suppose that someone were a serious Pastafarian. We would,

And this might be even if we could not come up with any decisive

argument against Pastafarianism. After all, Pastafarianism is designed as

based is misleading, and was planted by the Flying Saucer Monster.

Pastafarian will simply say that the evidence on which the argument is

to avoid arguments against it. When presented with such an argument, the